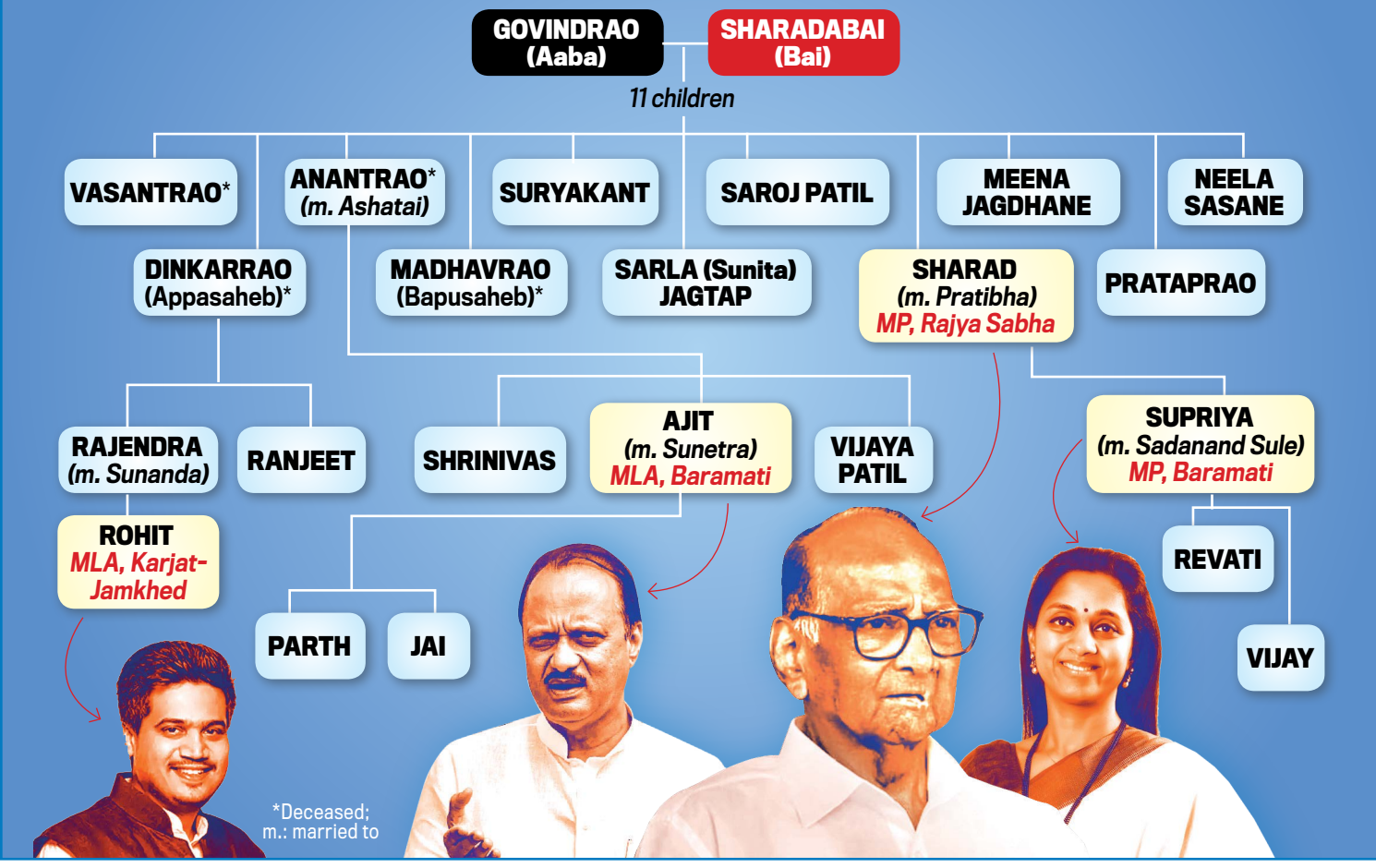
MEET THE PAWARS



Graphic by **TANMOY CHAKRABORTY**

Purandare, who was in the crosshairs of some hardline Maratha groups for his writings on the life and times of Chhatrapati Shivaji. "However, Ajit *dada* has no connection with any ideology," the associate guffawed.

Pune district NCP chief Pradeep Garatkar, who is with the Ajit camp, says it is Ajit who holds sway in Baramati now. "Though it was Saheb (Pawar Sr) who guided him, Dada (Ajit) is responsible for the development of Baramati," says Garatkar. Of the 10 NCP MLAs in Pune, at least seven are with Ajit. Garatkar, however, adds that the Pawar family has great "mutual understanding" and will not allow political differences to affect personal ties.

BJP legislator Rahul Kul, whose wife Kanchan had lost the 2019 general election against Sule, notes that Ajit's rebellion could change equations in the constituency. In 2019, Sule won by over 155,000 votes, with the Baramati assembly segment contributing over 125,000 votes, indicating it may not be a 'safe seat' anymore. There is speculation that Sunetra or Parth may be fielded against her. Of the six assembly seats, two each are held by the BJP, Congress and NCP.

A senior journalist who has observed Pawar Sr's political journey from close quarters, says the split could mark the decline of the NCP. The party had failed to come to power on its own in Maharashtra even at its peak and this could weaken it further. "Pawar's politics is the aggregation of the strength of sub-regional satraps in the NCP who owe allegiance to him... many of them have gone with Ajit. The Pawars also control several educational, commercial, and cooperative institutions together, which may make this split disruptive when it comes to their empire," he notes.

However, Chandrarao a.k.a. Chandraanna Taware, who was with Pawar Sr for almost four decades before they fell out, alleges the split is a chimera the Pawars have created to ensure Ajit gets a reprieve from the ED. "The Pawars can never split. They will always be together," he asserts, pointing to how events had transpired just days after Prime Minister Narendra Modi attacked the NCP for corruption at a public meeting. "Ajit had a choice... sit on a chair (as deputy CM), or on the floor (in jail)," alleges Taware.

Ranjankumar Taware, a BJP leader from Baramati, admits his party workers are not happy at the prospect of breaking bread with Ajit. He too reiterates the charge that the split is cosmetic and an attempt to spare Ajit legal action. "This will become clear in the Lok Sabha polls. Whether Sunetra or Parth will be fielded or a dummy candidate to give Sule a walkover will reveal if the breach is real," says Taware. Strange certainly are the ways of politics. ■